



LODESTAR
STRATEGY GROUP

CAMPAIGN STRATEGY · TARGETING · VOTER CONTACT

CONFIDENTIAL CAMPAIGN OPERATING PLAN

Defeating **[INCUMBENT]**: A Campaign Blueprint for **[DISTRICT]**

*District math, voter targeting, message architecture, and a full execution plan for the **[CYCLE/YEAR]** election in **[DISTRICT FULL NAME]**.*

PREPARED FOR

[CANDIDATE / COMMITTEE]

ENGAGEMENT

Campaign Operating Plan

CYCLE

[ELECTION DATE]

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TEMPLATE GUIDE

How to Build a District Plan From This Template

This is the reusable engine behind every Lodestar district plan. The structure, design, and strategic method are fixed. Your job per client is to replace every **[HIGHLIGHTED SLOT]** with that district's real data, and to remove the italic blue fill-notes and this page.

The five-step build

- 1 Run the research checklist.** Pull the district's most recent comparable election results by county, voter registration by party, and turnout history.
- 2 Identify the competitive county.** The "Volusia-equivalent" — the largest or most winnable county where the incumbent underperforms. This anchors the whole plan.
- 3 Find the local insight.** The single most compelling, sourced fact about this race (an underperformance, a swing, an intra-party attack). If none exists, say so honestly — the plan still works.
- 4 Fill every slot & compute the vote goal.** Replace all brackets; calculate 50%-plus-one at modeled turnout and set county targets.
- 5 Clean up.** Delete this page and every blue fill-note, proofread, and confirm no brackets remain.

THE HONESTY RULE

Not every district has a dramatic insight. Never invent one. If the incumbent is genuinely strong, the plan's value is an honest assessment of the realistic path — including, where true, that the seat is not winnable this cycle. That candor is what makes the brand credible.

Legend: **[YELLOW SLOTS]** = replace with district data. *Blue italic notes like this one* = instructions to you; delete before delivery.

CONTENTS

Campaign Operating Plan

This plan converts a strategic thesis into an executable campaign blueprint. It is organized in fifteen parts, beginning with the district math that defines the path to victory and ending with the benchmarks that measure progress against it.

01 Executive Summary & Path to Victory 4

02 District Math & Vote Goal 5

03 Voter Universe & Targeting 7

04 Message Architecture 8

05 The Case Against the Incumbent: Contrast Research 9

06 Outreach Calendar & Phasing 10

07 Direct Mail Program 11

08 Digital & Social Strategy 12

09 Field Strategy 13

10 Coalition Strategy 14

11 Fundraising Plan & Budget Tiers 15

12 Earned Media Plan 16

13 Candidate Profile Requirements 16

14 Risk Assessment & Mitigation 17

15 Benchmarks & Success Metrics 18

THE CENTRAL FINDING

[ONE-SENTENCE CENTRAL FINDING] — e.g., "In the most recent election, [INCUMBENT] carried [DISTRICT] by [X] points, but won [COMPETITIVE COUNTY], the district's largest, by just [Y]." The path to defeating the incumbent runs through that county, a disciplined local message, and a turnout model that does not collapse to a normal baseline.

Fill-note: The Central Finding is the most important sentence in the plan. Lead with the strongest, most specific, sourced fact about the race.

SECTION 01

Executive Summary & Path to Victory

[INCUMBENT] is beatable, but only under specific conditions. [ONE-TO-TWO SENTENCES ON THE INCUMBENT'S PROFILE AND ANY UNDERPERFORMANCE]. The question this plan answers is not whether the incumbent is vulnerable, but exactly how a challenger converts that vulnerability into 50%-plus-one.

The thesis

[INCUMBENT] wins when the race is nationalized and base turnout returns to form. They lose when the race is localized around the everyday costs facing [DISTRICT] households — [TOP 2-3 LOCAL ISSUES, e.g. insurance, housing, jobs] — and when the challenger assembles a coalition of the base, a majority of independents, and a meaningful slice of the incumbent's own party who are dissatisfied with them.

Fill-note: Localize the issues to the district. Coastal FL = insurance; Rust Belt = manufacturing/jobs; Southwest = water/cost of living; etc.

The five conditions for victory

- 1 Win [COMPETITIVE COUNTY] decisively.** The district's most winnable major county. It is the mathematical cornerstone; the plan targets a clear win here.
- 2 Hold the margins in the strongholds.** [STRONGHOLD COUNTIES] cannot be won, but the incumbent's margins there must be capped, not conceded.
- 3 Localize the message relentlessly.** Every paid and earned communication ties the incumbent's national focus to a concrete local cost.
- 4 Build a broad, non-partisan-feeling coalition.** The challenger must read as a local alternative, not a national partisan.
- 5 Sustain turnout above the baseline.** An aggressive, mail-forward, field-heavy contact program keeps a favorable turnout shape from reverting.

WHAT THIS PLAN IS — AND IS NOT

This is a strategic operating plan grounded in public election and registration data. It defines who to target, what to say, when to say it, and how to measure it. It is not a substitute for a licensed voter file (VAN/L2) or for district-specific polling; both are recommended early investments and are noted where the plan depends on them.

District Math & Vote Goal

Everything in this plan is anchored to one number: the votes required to win, and where they must come from. **[MOST RECENT COMPARABLE ELECTION]** is the most relevant baseline available, and it reveals **[a more competitive / the true shape of the]** district beneath the topline margin.

The baseline, by county

[INCUMBENT] defeated **[OPPONENT]** **[WINNER VOTES]** to **[LOSER VOTES]** — a margin of **[MARGIN]** on **[TOTAL]** cast. But that margin is not evenly distributed: **[ONE SENTENCE ON WHERE THE MARGIN IS CONCENTRATED VS. WHERE THE RACE IS CLOSE]**.

COUNTY	[INCUMBENT]	[OPPONENT]	MARGIN	TOTAL VOTES	SHARE
[Competitive County]	[#]	[#]	[+#]	[#]	[%]
[County 2]	[#]	[#]	[+#]	[#]	[%]
[County 3]	[#]	[#]	[+#]	[#]	[%]
[County 4]	[#]	[#]	[+#]	[#]	[%]
[County 5 / add rows as needed]	[#]	[#]	[+#]	[#]	[%]
District	[#]	[#]	[+#]	[#]	100%

Source: **[STATE]** Division of Elections / **[COUNTY]** Supervisor of Elections, official results, **[ELECTION DATE]**.

Fill-note: Order counties largest-to-smallest by vote share. Mark the competitive county's margin green (class "pos"). Add or remove rows to match the district's county count.

THE STRUCTURAL INSIGHT

[WHERE THE MARGIN COMES FROM] — e.g., "Counties **[X and Y]** alone delivered a combined **[+#]** margin, more than half the district-wide cushion, on just **[%]** of the vote, while **[competitive county]**, at nearly **[%]** of the district, delivered only **[+#]**." The arithmetic of this race is the arithmetic of that fact.

The Vote Goal

A [CYCLE] general will turn out more voters than [the baseline election]. The plan models three turnout scenarios and sets the vote goal against the most realistic one.

[~XXXXK]

MODELED TURNOUT

[XXX,XXX]

VOTES TO WIN (50% + 1)

[+X → 0]

COMPETITIVE COUNTY MUST FLIP

Fill-note: Modeled turnout = a reasonable general-election estimate (typically well above a special, below a presidential). Votes-to-win = half of modeled turnout, plus one.

ILLUSTRATIVE WIN CONDITION

Victory requires moving the county mix: winning [competitive county] by a clear margin (target [D/R +X to +Y]), holding [swing county] to a low-single-digit incumbent win, and capping the stronghold margins so the [N] strongest counties net the incumbent no more than ~[#] votes.

County-by-county targets

COUNTY	BASELINE	[CYCLE] TARGET	STRATEGIC OBJECTIVE
[Competitive County]	[R/D +X]	[D/R +X to +Y]	Win decisively — the must-win cornerstone
[Swing County]	[+X]	[+X to +Y]	Compress; persuadable suburbanites
[County]	[+X]	[+X to +Y]	Contain; limit the bleed
[Stronghold]	[+X]	[+X to +Y]	Hold the gap; stronghold
[Deepest Stronghold]	[+X]	[+X to +Y]	Minimize; deepest margin

Targets are strategic objectives, not forecasts. Final goals should be calibrated against a modeled voter file and at least one district poll.

TRANSLATING THE MATH INTO A DIRECTIVE

The campaign's single operating sentence: "[THE TWO-PART DIRECTIVE: win the competitive county by X, and cap the strongholds at Y net votes]." Every resource decision is judged against whether it advances those two targets.

Voter Universe & Targeting

Broad outreach wins nothing without precise targeting. This section defines the discrete voter universes the campaign will model, score, and contact — turning broad goals into specific, addressable lists.

The targeting priorities

[DISTRICT] registration [leans / splits / favors] [party], and independents (NPA/unaffiliated) are a decisive bloc. The winning coalition is built from three layers, each requiring a different contact strategy.

UNIVERSE	OBJECTIVE	PRIMARY CHANNEL
High-propensity base voters	Turnout / consolidation	Mail + field + digital
Inconsistent base voters	Mobilization — the largest upside	Field + mail chase + text
Independents who vote midterms	Persuasion + turnout	Mail + Facebook + digital
Older independents (55+)	Persuasion on cost-of-living	Mail + Facebook
Moderate / defector opposition partisans	Persuasion + permission to cross over	Mail + earned media
Veterans (all parties)	Persuasion on local-service contrast	Mail + targeted events
Suburban women	Persuasion on affordability + services	Digital + mail
Seniors (benefits + costs)	Persuasion + turnout	Mail + Facebook + phones
Incumbent under-performers / no-shows	Suppression of the incumbent's ceiling	Contrast mail + digital

THE HIGHEST-LEVERAGE UNIVERSE

The two groups with the most upside are **inconsistent base voters** (in the file but skip midterms) and **older independents** (persuadable on cost-of-living). [COMPETITIVE COUNTY] is where both are most concentrated.

REQUIRED EARLY INVESTMENT

A modeled voter file (VAN/L2/TargetSmart) is the foundation for every targeted contact in this plan. Budget for file access and modeling in the first 60 days; mail and field cannot be efficiently targeted without it.

Message Architecture

A campaign needs one message, repeated through many doors. The architecture below gives the candidate a single core frame and audience-specific expressions of it.

Core message

CORE

"[INCUMBENT] is more focused on national attention than on delivering for the families of [DISTRICT]."

Issue messages — the local proof points

ECONOMIC / AFFORDABILITY

"[TOP LOCAL COST ISSUE] is crushing families and retirees here — and our representative is chasing headlines instead of fighting for relief."

SENIORS

"Protect Social Security and Medicare, and answer the phone when a constituent needs help. That is the job."

VETERANS

"[DISTRICT] is home to thousands of veterans. They deserve a representative who treats veterans' services as a first priority."

CONTRAST

"[INCUMBENT] creates controversy. The district needs results."

THE DISCIPLINE RULE

The sharp version of the contrast is not "the incumbent is offensive." It is: "**Their controversy is not just offensive — it distracts from delivery.**" This converts a values argument that splits voters into an effectiveness argument that unites them.

Fill-note: Swap the issue messages for the district's real top issues. The structure stays; the specifics change.

The Case Against the Incumbent: Contrast Research

Effective contrast is sourced, specific, and effectiveness-framed. The goal is not to prove the incumbent is controversial — voters know that — but to prove the controversy costs the district.

The validator

[STRONGEST SOURCED CRITICISM OF THE INCUMBENT — ideally from their own party. Describe it and cite it.]

[THE KEY QUOTE OR FINDING, PARAPHRASED] — the kind of intra-party verdict that gives moderate [opposition-party] voters permission to cross over. It is not a partisan talking point; it is a judgment from the incumbent's own side.

Source: [CITATION]

Fill-note: The gold standard is criticism from the incumbent's own party (as DeSantis attacked Fine in FL-06). If none exists, use the strongest sourced criticism available, and lower the emphasis accordingly.

The vulnerability inventory

Items marked ✓ are established in public reporting; items marked □ require verification before use.

Effectiveness & profile

- ◆ [Underperformance vs. baseline, if any]
- ◆ [National focus over district service]
- ◆ [Limited local deliverables]
- ◆ [Other]

Character & standing

- ◆ [Intra-party friction]
- ◆ [Reputation / rhetoric]
- ◆ [Weakness with moderates/NPAs]
- ◆ [Voting record items to document]

THE CONTRAST DOCTRINE

Lead with effectiveness, not outrage. Tie every attack back to a local consequence. A full opposition research book is a separate, larger work product; this section frames the strategy.

SECTION 06

Outreach Calendar & Phasing

A campaign is a sequence, not a single message. Each phase has a job, and voters should hear a different thing in each. The calendar runs from launch through Election Day on [ELECTION DATE].

LAUNCH	Announcement & Infrastructure Define rationale, stand up finance and data operations, secure voter-file access, recruit founding volunteers.
EARLY	Biography / Introduction Establish local roots and credibility before opponents define the candidate.
MID	Persuasion Drive affordability and seniors messages to independents and moderates.
LATE	Contrast Sharpen the incumbent contrast, sourced and local.
PRE-E-DAY	Vote-by-Mail / Early Vote Chase Drive return of mail ballots and bank early votes among supporters.
[E-DAY]	Election Day GOTV Full turnout operation on identified supporters who have not yet voted.

PHASE DISCIPLINE

Persuasion precedes contrast; contrast precedes chase. The most common challenger error is running contrast too early or too late. Hold the sequence.

Fill-note: Insert the district's actual primary and general dates, and state vote-by-mail / early-vote rules and deadlines.

SECTION 07

Direct Mail Program

Older voters still read their mail. A disciplined, repeated program is the backbone of voter contact — especially in [COMPETITIVE COUNTY] and among seniors. The program assumes 7–9 distinct drops, layered by audience.

#	PIECE	AUDIENCE	PHASE	TYPE
1	Candidate Introduction	Persuasion universe, district-wide	Early	Positive
2	Affordability / [Local Issue]	Independents, seniors, suburban women	Early	Positive
3	Social Security & Medicare	Seniors 55+, all parties	Mid	Positive
4	Veterans	Veteran households	Mid	Positive
5	Endorsements / Validators	Persuasion universe	Mid	Positive
6	Contrast: Headlines vs. Results	Moderates, independents	Late	Contrast
7	[Competitive County] Local Issues	[Competitive County] households	Late	Positive
8	VBM / Early-Vote Chase	Outstanding ballot requesters	Late	Turnout
9	Election Day Reminder	Identified supporters, not-yet-voted	Final	Turnout

[COMPETITIVE COUNTY] WEIGHTING

Because it is the cornerstone, [competitive county] receives additional drops the strongholds do not. Mail dollars follow the district math.

Positive vs. contrast balance

Roughly two-thirds positive, one-third contrast. Over-indexing on contrast risks turning off persuadable moderates.

Senior & absentee focus

Seniors and habitual mail voters get the most touches. The benefits and chase pieces are the highest-priority drops.

Digital & Social Strategy

Each platform does a different job. The plan does not treat "digital" as one thing: Facebook reaches older voters, X drives the media narrative, and Instagram/TikTok produce shareable clips and recruit younger volunteers.

PLATFORM	PRIMARY ROLE	AUDIENCE
Facebook	Persuasion + turnout (paid + organic)	Older voters, local community groups
X / Twitter	Media & elite narrative, rapid response	Reporters, activists, donors
Instagram	Biography, shareable moments	Younger voters, suburban women
TikTok	Viral clips, volunteer recruitment	Younger voters, volunteers
Email	Fundraising + GOTV + list-building	Supporters, donors

FACEBOOK IS THE PRIORITY BUY

Given the [DISTRICT] electorate's age profile, Facebook — paid and organic — is typically the highest-value digital channel and should receive the largest share of digital spend.

- ◆ Local-issue graphics
 - ◆ Short candidate videos
 - ◆ County-specific ad sets ([competitive county] weighted)
 - ◆ Contrast ads (effectiveness-framed)
- ◆ Retargeting audiences
 - ◆ Independent- and senior-specific variants
 - ◆ Volunteer-recruitment ads
 - ◆ Fundraising ads

Field Strategy

"Knock doors" is not a plan. A field operation specifies who is contacted, where, when, with what script, and how often — built to identify supporters early and turn them out late.

- 1 **Door-knocking targets.** Prioritize [competitive county] precincts dense with inconsistent base voters and persuadable independents.
- 2 **Volunteer recruitment.** Build a pipeline from launch via local groups, [local campuses/orgs], and digital ads.
- 3 **Phone & text banking.** Supplement doors; reach dispersed, lower-propensity voters at scale.
- 4 **Voter ID program.** Every contact updates a support score; build a clean list of identified supporters.
- 5 **VBM & early-vote chase.** Match supporters against ballot-return data; re-contact those who have not voted.
- 6 **Election Day operation.** Full GOTV on identified supporters, concentrated in priority [competitive county] precincts.

Canvass scripts

Persuasion script (affordability + effectiveness contrast) for independents/moderates; turnout script (plan-to-vote) for identified supporters.

Geographic concentration

Field hours concentrate where they move the math: [competitive county] first, then persuadable pockets elsewhere. Deep strongholds are not a door-knocking priority.

Coalition Strategy

The challenger must read as a broad local alternative, not a partisan opponent. That perception is built through deliberate outreach to community institutions.

Civic & community

- ◆ Veterans groups
- ◆ Retiree communities
- ◆ HOAs
- ◆ Civic clubs
- ◆ Faith communities

Economic & labor

- ◆ Local business owners
- ◆ Chambers of commerce
- ◆ Educators
- ◆ Firefighters & nurses
- ◆ Public employees

Political

- ◆ [Base-party] clubs
- ◆ Independent voters
- ◆ [Opposition] defectors
- ◆ Issue coalitions

THE COALITION TEST

Success is when a persuadable voter describes the challenger not as "the [party] running against [incumbent]," but as "the local candidate a lot of people I trust are supporting." Cross-partisan and civic endorsements outweigh national validators.

Fill-note: Add district-specific institutions where you can name them (a major local employer, a well-known civic group, the area's dominant industry).

SECTION 11

Fundraising Plan & Budget Tiers

A strategy without money is theory. [IF APPLICABLE: a fundraising fact about this race or this district's prior cycle that shows resources are attainable.] The plan defines three budget tiers and the program each funds.

BARE MINIMUM [\$X-XM] Digital-forward, limited mail, volunteer-driven field. Competitive only with outside help. High variance.	COMPETITIVE [\$X-XM] Full mail, paid Facebook at scale, paid field, voter file + modeling. The realistic floor for a win.	FULLY FUNDED [\$XM+] Everything above plus broadcast/cable, polling cadence, large paid field, research operation.
◆ Local donor strategy & finance committee ◆ Call-time schedule ◆ Online / small-dollar program		◆ National fundraising (issue-driven) ◆ Email program tied to news moments ◆ Budget tiering against the calendar

THE FUNDRAISING REALITY

Money alone does not win; the discipline of this plan converts dollars into the specific county targets that decide the seat. Fund the competitive tier as the baseline; treat the fully-funded tier as the goal.

Fill-note: Size the budget tiers to the race — House districts differ widely; a state-legislative race is an order of magnitude smaller. Adjust the dollar ranges accordingly.

SECTION 12

Earned Media Plan

Earned media keeps the race feeling local. The goal is a steady drumbeat of local-issue coverage that reinforces the effectiveness contrast.

- ◆ Local newspaper outreach ([name the main local paper(s)])
- ◆ Local talk-radio appearances
- ◆ Letters to the editor (surrogate-driven)
- ◆ Press releases tied to local news
- ◆ Debate challenges to [incumbent]
- ◆ Town halls in priority counties
- ◆ Veterans roundtables
- ◆ [Local-issue] press events

EARNED-MEDIA FRAME

Every press moment ladders back to the core message: local results vs. national headlines.

SECTION 13

Candidate Profile Requirements

Not every challenger can execute this strategy. The plan is built around a specific profile.

ATTRIBUTE	WHY IT MATTERS
Local credibility / [competitive county] tie	The cornerstone county responds to a genuinely local figure
Disciplined temperament	The campaign wins on message discipline
Cross-partisan appeal	Must speak to seniors and the opposition without sounding like a national partisan
Clean personal background	The race is about the incumbent's conduct; the challenger cannot muddy that contrast
Fundraising capacity	The competitive tier requires a candidate who can raise
Comfort with contrast	Must deliver the effectiveness contrast credibly

SECTION 14

Risk Assessment & Mitigation

A serious plan names its threats and answers them, ranked by capacity to end the path to victory.

RISK	MITIGATION
The race nationalizes	Relentless localization; never take the national bait.
National figure overwhelms local issues	Decouple the incumbent from the national brand; lean on intra-party criticism.
Base turnout reverts to baseline	Aggressive field + chase; cap stronghold margins via contrast mail.
Challenger painted as too partisan	Candidate profile + message discipline; lead with affordability and effectiveness.
Insufficient money for mail	Tiered budget; protect mail and [competitive county] field first.
Base turnout collapses	Early voter-ID + consolidation; treat base turnout as a field priority.
[Competitive county] underperforms	Over-weight it in every channel; it is the single point of failure.
Late outside-group spending	Reserve late ad inventory; bank early votes before the flood.

THE SINGLE GREATEST RISK

The race nationalizing. The incumbent is strongest when the contest is about party, weakest when it is about [local cost] and an absent representative. Discipline against nationalization is the first job.

SECTION 15

Benchmarks & Success Metrics

What gets measured gets managed. The campaign tracks concrete weekly and cumulative targets, all laddering up to the two numbers that decide the race.

Contact

- ◆ Doors knocked (weekly + cumulative)
- ◆ Calls completed
- ◆ Texts sent / responded
- ◆ Mail delivered (by drop)

Turnout

- ◆ VBM ballots requested (by party)
- ◆ VBM ballots returned
- ◆ Early votes banked

Digital & money

- ◆ Facebook impressions / reach
- ◆ Weekly fundraising vs. goal
- ◆ Email list growth
- ◆ Volunteer shifts completed

Outcome proxies

- ◆ Identified-supporter count by county
- ◆ County turnout goals tracking
- ◆ [Competitive county] margin (polling / VBM proxy)

THE TWO SCOREBOARD NUMBERS

Beneath all operational metrics sit two outcome targets: (1) [competitive county] at [target margin] or better, and (2) the strongholds netting the incumbent no more than ~[#] votes. Every weekly report ties back to both.

ENGAGEMENT TERMS

Scope of Work & Investment

This campaign operating plan is delivered as a fixed-fee strategic product, prepared specifically for [DISTRICT].

DELIVERABLE	INCLUDED
Campaign Operating Plan — this complete 15-part document, built on [DISTRICT]'s real election data.	✓
Data-grounded district math — county-by-county baseline, turnout scenarios, vote goal, and county targets.	✓
Message & contrast framework — core message, audience-mapped issue messages, and a sourced contrast strategy.	✓
Full execution playbook — phased calendar, mail, digital, field, coalition, and benchmark scorecard.	✓
Strategy presentation & briefing — one live walkthrough with the candidate and senior staff.	✓
One round of revisions — a single consolidated revision within 21 days of delivery.	✓
Total Engagement Fee — Fixed	[\$4,500 base / \$7,500 complete]

PAYMENT Payment in full secures the engagement; the finished plan is delivered on receipt. Check or ACH.	TIMELINE Final plan delivered within [1-2 weeks] of payment.	WHAT'S INCLUDED A complete, ready-to-execute campaign plan for [DISTRICT] — delivered as a finished product.
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Terms & Conditions

This engagement covers the strategic planning product described above. Voter-file licensing, data modeling, polling, mail production, and media placement are billed separately or under a subsequent agreement. All electoral figures are drawn from public sources as cited and are current as of the date of this plan. Work product is confidential and prepared for the named client's exclusive use. This plan provides professional strategic guidance and does not guarantee any electoral outcome. Payment is due in full to secure the engagement, and the completed product is delivered on receipt.

CLIENT — AUTHORIZED SIGNATURE & DATE

LODESTAR STRATEGY GROUP & DATE